

PTSD (post-traumatic stress disorder)

PTSD (post-traumatic stress disorder) is a mental health condition caused by very stressful, frightening or distressing events. Medicines and therapy can help manage it.

Get urgent help

Support is available if you or someone you know is having a mental health crisis or emergency, no matter what you're going through.

Find out where to get urgent help for mental health (Link: www.nhs.uk/nhs-services/mental-health-services/where-to-get-urgent-help-for-mental-health/)

Symptoms of PTSD (post-traumatic stress disorder)

The main symptom of PTSD (post-traumatic stress disorder) is when you keep having distressing thoughts about a traumatic event or experience.

You may experience this as flashbacks, vivid or intrusive images or thoughts, and recurring dreams or nightmares.

Symptoms of PTSD in adults

Symptoms of PTSD in adults can include:

- avoiding people or places that remind you of the event
- not being able to fully remember the traumatic event
- negative thoughts or beliefs about yourself and not doing the things you used to enjoy
- problems with your relationships, such as communicating less with other people
- feeling disconnected from yourself and the world around you (dissociation)
- finding it difficult to control your feelings and emotions, or not experiencing emotions at all
- changes in your mood, such as having a low mood or being more irritable or angry than usual
- difficulty sleeping
- feeling very anxious and looking for danger all the time (hypervigilance)
- repeated headaches, tummy problems or pain anywhere in the body that has no physical cause

You may experience symptoms straight after the traumatic event or many months, or even years, later.

Symptoms of CPTSD (complex post-traumatic stress disorder) are largely the same as PTSD but have different causes.

Symptoms of PTSD in children

Symptoms of PTSD in children include:

- having dreams about the traumatic event, which can then become nightmares about monsters
- re-enacting the trauma through play – for example, using toy cars to re-enact a car crash
- sleep problems, such as refusing to sleep on their own
- wetting the bed, even if they did not before the traumatic event
- losing interest in things they used to enjoy
- talking about death or dying
- lots of tummy aches and headaches

Causes of PTSD (post-traumatic stress disorder)

PTSD (post-traumatic stress disorder) is caused by experiencing a traumatic event such as:

- a serious or life-threatening accident
- physical or sexual assault
- abuse, including childhood or domestic abuse
- doing certain jobs, such as a police officer, paramedic or healthcare worker
- serious health problems, such as being in intensive care
- a difficult birth, or your baby died

- war

You may have experienced the traumatic event yourself, seen it happen to someone else, or heard about it happening to someone you're close to.

CPTSD (complex post-traumatic stress disorder)

The types of trauma that can cause CPTSD can include child abuse or neglect, ongoing domestic violence or abuse, and repeatedly witnessing violence or abuse.

More information

- What causes complex PTSD? (Mind) (Link: <https://www.mind.org.uk/information-support/types-of-mental-health-problems/post-traumatic-stress-disorder-ptsd/complex-ptsd/#WhatCausesComplexPTSD>)

See a GP if:

- you think you have symptoms of PTSD (post-traumatic stress disorder)
- you've been diagnosed with PTSD and treatments are not helping (or speak to your mental health specialist if you have one)

If you're worried about someone else, encourage them to speak to their GP.

Other ways to get help

NHS talking therapies for anxiety and depression can help with PTSD.

If you're 18 or over (or 16 or over in some areas), you can refer yourself directly to an NHS talking therapies service without a referral from a GP.



Find NHS talking therapies for anxiety and depression (Link: www.nhs.uk/nhs-services/mental-health-services/find-nhs-talking-therapies-for-anxiety-and-depression/)

If you're under 18, find out more about mental health support for children and young people (Link: <https://www.nhs.uk/mental-health/children-and-young-adults/mental-health-support/how-to-get-support/>).

How PTSD (post-traumatic stress disorder) is diagnosed

If you go to a GP because you think you may have PTSD (post-traumatic stress disorder), they'll ask you about your symptoms.

They will also refer you to a mental health specialist, such as a talking therapies service or a psychiatrist.

The mental health specialist will ask you about things like your mood, behaviour, health and family history.

Treatments for PTSD (post-traumatic stress disorder)

PTSD (post-traumatic stress disorder) usually gets better for most people, but symptoms can be more severe and last longer for some.

There are treatments that can help manage your symptoms.

A GP and mental health specialist will work with you to create a treatment plan.

Treatments you may have include:

- trauma therapy, such as trauma-focused cognitive behavioural therapy (CBT) (Link: www.nhs.uk/tests-and-treatments/cognitive-behavioural-therapy-cbt/)
- eye-movement desensitisation and reprocessing (EMDR), where eye movements are used to help process traumatic memories
- medicines, usually an antidepressant (Link: www.nhs.uk/medicines/antidepressants/)

The medicines can cause side effects. These will vary depending on which medicine you take and how your body responds to it.

You'll usually have appointments at a GP surgery, clinic or hospital.

If doctors are worried you're at risk of self-harm (Link: www.nhs.uk/mental-health/feelings-symptoms-behaviours/behaviours/self-harm/), suicide or harming someone else, you may need to stay in hospital or have support from a crisis team at home.

Important

Do not stop taking your PTSD medicine unless you are told to by a doctor, even if you feel better.

Some medicines for PTSD are not safe to take if you're pregnant. Talk to your doctor if you're pregnant or planning a pregnancy.

More information

- Treatment for PTSD (Mind) (Link: <https://www.mind.org.uk/information-support/types-of-mental-health-problems/post-traumatic-stress-disorder-ptsd/treatment-for-ptsd/>)
- NHS medicines A to Z: find your medicine (Link: www.nhs.uk/medicines/)

Things you can do that help with PTSD (post-traumatic stress disorder)

There are things you can do yourself that help with some of the symptoms of PTSD (post-traumatic stress disorder), such as flashbacks.

A mental health professional will help you learn and practise skills that can help manage your PTSD.

Do

- ✓ talk to someone about how you're feeling, either a friend or family member, or through an online support group
- ✓ keep a diary to help spot the things that can trigger flashbacks, such as certain smells or sounds
- ✓ try breathing exercises (Link: www.nhs.uk/mental-health/self-help/guides-tools-and-activities/breathing-exercises-for-stress/)
- ✓ stay active
- ✓ have a healthy, balanced diet
- ✓ try to get enough sleep

Don't

- ✗ do not take recreational drugs
- ✗ do not smoke
- ✗ do not drink too much alcohol

More information

- Helping yourself with PTSD (Mind) (Link: <https://www.mind.org.uk/information-support/types-of-mental-health-problems/post-traumatic-stress-disorder-ptsd/helping-yourself-with-ptsd/>)
- Post-traumatic stress self-help guide (Cumbria, Northumberland, Tyne and Wear NHS Foundation Trust) (Link: <https://selfhelp.cntw.nhs.uk/self-help-guides/post-traumatic-stress>)
- Self-help CBT techniques from Every Mind Matters (Link: <https://www.nhs.uk/every-mind-matters/mental-wellbeing-tips/self-help-cbt-techniques/>) – learn how to manage stress and worry, and boost your mental wellbeing
- NHS Better Health (Link: <https://www.nhs.uk/better-health/>) – free tools and support to help you get active, quit smoking and drink less

Help and support for PTSD (post-traumatic stress disorder)

If you have PTSD (post-traumatic stress disorder), you will be supported by a mental health specialist or GP.

There are also national and local charities such as Mind that offer information and support for anyone affected by PTSD.

Support groups and forums

It can be helpful to speak to other people who have PTSD.

There are many people offering support and sharing their stories in support groups, forums and on social media.

- Online and local support groups (Mind) (Link: <https://www.mind.org.uk/information-support/guides-to-support-and-services/peer-support-groups/how-to-find-a-support-group/>)
- Local support groups (Rethink Mental Illness) (Link: https://www.rethink.org/help-in-your-area/support-groups/?_gl=1*1jfb80p*_up*MQ..*_gs*MQ..&gclid=EAIaIQobChMIj7Wd5Oq_kgMVJ5pQBh0ZzAmEEAAYASABEgIRsvD_BwE&gbraid=0AAAAAD1v)
- Peer support service (Combat Stress) (Link: <https://combatstress.org.uk/get-help/how-we-help/peer-support>)
- Support for families affected by a perinatal mental illness (PANDAS Foundation) (Link: <https://pandasfoundation.org.uk/how-we-can-support-you/>)

Comments in forums and on social media are often based on personal experience and should not be taken as medical advice.

Support for family, friends and carers

If you care for someone who has PTSD, you can get support from charities.

- Support for families of veterans (Combat Stress) (Link: <https://combatstress.org.uk/support-for-families-of-veterans>)
- Advice for loved ones and carers (Rethink Mental Illness) (Link: https://www.rethink.org/advice-and-information/carers-hub/advice-for-loved-ones-and-carers/?_gl=1*b8ecys*_up*MQ..*_gs*MQ..&gclid=EAIaIQobChMIj7Wd5Oq_kgMVJ5pQBh0ZzAmEEAAYASABEgIRsvD_BwE&gbraid=0AAAAAD1v)
- Supporting someone after crime (Victim Support) (Link: <https://www.victimsupport.org.uk/help-and-support/supporting-someone-after-crime/>)

More information and advice

There are charities that offer support and information if you're affected by PTSD.

- Anxiety UK (Link: <https://www.anxietyuk.org.uk/>)
- Mental Health Foundation (Link: <https://www.mentalhealth.org.uk/>)
- Mind (Link: <https://www.mind.org.uk/>)
- PANDAS Foundation (Link: <https://pandasfoundation.org.uk/>)
- Rape Crisis England and Wales (Link: <https://rapecrisis.org.uk/>)
- Victim Support (Link: <https://www.victimsupport.org.uk/>)